

Property Investment Purchase Checklist — Northern Territory

Due diligence for buying an investment property in Australia's most tax-friendly jurisdiction for landholding.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only — not financial, tax or legal advice. Engage a qualified accountant, mortgage broker, and conveyancer before purchasing.

Section 1 — Structuring the Purchase (The NT's Genuine Advantage)

- ☐ [] **Understand the NT's standout feature: no land tax at all.** The Northern Territory is the **only Australian jurisdiction with no general land tax** — investors pay zero annual land tax on rental properties, a genuinely significant structural advantage over every state and the ACT for ongoing holding costs.
- ☐ [] **Understand the NT also has no foreign buyer duty surcharge.** Along with the ACT lacking a land tax surcharge for some categories, the NT is unique in having **neither a foreign buyer stamp duty surcharge nor a land tax surcharge** — foreign buyers pay the same standard rates as Australian citizens.
- ☐ [] **Still decide on ownership structure carefully** — even without land tax considerations, individual, joint, trust, or company structures carry different income tax and asset-protection implications.
- ☐ [] **Understand you'll pay standard transfer duty as an investor** — the NT's formula-based/tiered duty system applies to all buyers, with no investor-specific concession or exemption (the same as first home buyers pay, since the NT doesn't offer FHB duty relief either).
- ☐ [] **Check whether the House and Land Package Exemption (HLPE) could apply to your purchase**, if you're building rather than buying established — this isn't restricted to first home buyers, and gives a full duty waiver on eligible single-contract packages until 30 June 2027.
- ☐ [] **Get investment-specific finance pre-approval.**

Section 2 — Due Diligence on the Property Itself

- ☐ [] **Order a building and pest inspection within your cooling-off window.**
- ☐ [] **Have a conveyancer or solicitor review the contract before you sign.**
- ☐ [] **Pay particular attention to cyclone/storm resilience** if purchasing in Darwin or the Top End — this affects both insurance costs and long-term maintenance budgeting.
- ☐ [] **Research the local rental market specifically** — vacancy rates, comparable rents, and tenant demand, noting the NT's rental market is significantly influenced by defence force postings, resource sector cycles, and government employment.

Section 3 — Setting Up for Compliance From Day One

- ☐ [] **Budget for compliance with the Residential Tenancies Act 1999**, including the rent-bidding/gazumping ban and the specific rent increase conditions.
- ☐ [] **Decide on self-management vs. a property manager** — genuinely worth weighing given the NT's distinctive tenant population (higher turnover in some markets due to postings/contracts) and climate-related maintenance demands.
- ☐ [] **Arrange landlord insurance**, specifically checking cyclone/storm coverage given the NT's climate.
- ☐ [] **Engage a quantity surveyor for a tax depreciation schedule** shortly after settlement — see the separate Tax & Depreciation Checklist in this series.

Section 4 — Understanding the Current Tax Environment

- ☐ [] **Be aware Commonwealth CGT settings for investment property are changing**, with reforms affecting the CGT discount generally applying from **1 July 2027** — confirm the finalised current position with your accountant.
- ☐ [] **Get advice on purchase and sale timing relative to this changeover** if your investment horizon spans the 2027 transition.

Quick Reference — NT Investment Property Snapshot (July 2026)

ITEM	DETAIL
Land tax	None — the only Australian jurisdiction without one
Foreign buyer surcharge (duty)	None
Foreign buyer land tax surcharge	Not applicable (no land tax)
Standard transfer duty	Formula-based under \$525,000; tiered flat rates above
HLPE duty waiver	Available for eligible house-and-land packages, until 30 June 2027

Duty and grant settings change with territory budgets — always confirm current figures with the Territory Revenue Office before settling on a purchase strategy.

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